



Film Title Design History

Take a journey through time to survey the evolution of film title design, all the way from lettering to colours. <http://digit.in/feb21-29>



Evolution Of Movie Posters

Starting from 19th century France, take a look back at the evolution of film posters and its trends. <http://digit.in/feb21-30>

toys. This method is still used, to this day, by a few production companies.

Things such as opening titles and end credit rolls were also created in the most primitive ways. All the information was written on a long piece of paper or plastic, and then affixed onto a rolling drum or platform. It is then simply rolled in front of a recording camera and added into the movie. You can get a clearer idea of the process from the image at the bottom of this page, where they are filming the iconic opening crawl for Star Wars: The Empire Strikes Back (Episode V). Despite sounding smooth on paper, it was actually one of the hardest shots for the franchise. The four feet long artwork was recorded by setting a camera real low to the ground and using a tilting lens to eliminate most of the focus problems. Testing would take days, as everything had to be lined up flawlessly. Any little blemish, bump, or movement of the camera could ruin the entire 2000-frame-long take.

Credits that had a movie scene playing in the background were achieved using an optical printer. The film titles or graphic sequences

were simply hand-illustrated cards, photographed and composited onto another film. Filmmakers also used various types of fonts and colour themes to convey the genre or subject of the movie in the title cards.

GRAPHIC DESIGN

Once a movie is locked-in and ready to be shown, you need to promote and advertise it. And that requires posters. In the early days, film posters were exclusively produced for theatres exhibiting the movie, and were required to be returned to the distributor, right after the film left the theatre. This is for two major reasons. For one, printing was expensive. And secondly, posters were difficult to create, as they had to be painstakingly hand-drawn and painted. Other times, photos were manually cut and pasted using various tools with utmost

precision. These tools included X-Acto knives, tweezers, and a snot-like adhesive known as rubber cement, whose toxic fumes were notorious for causing light-headedness when inhaled. Letters and words were also treated in a similar manner. Although, this time, designers would come up with a basic idea of the font size and style they needed. An order is then sent to a typesetter who prints them overnight, so the former could implement them the next day. Again, just like film editing, this entire affair is first attempted on a rough print, before getting finalised and laid out onto the main sheet. These days, thanks



Credits with movie scene running in the background



Aligning pictures onto a drawing board

to Photoshop, no human being has to endure this insufferable workflow.

The way post-production technology has evolved over the years is truly astonishing. It still goes on to show the things we take for granted these days. What we covered here is just the tip of the iceberg. A small portion of the many traditional ideas that would go on to set the foundations for the digital film revolution. Even today, some of these old-school techniques are adopted by filmmakers around the world. Christopher Nolan and Quentin Tarantino are great examples of directors who still shoot their movies on film, but choose to edit them digitally. This ongoing charade between analogue and digital filmmaking is something that will continue to grow, and spark even more discussions in the years ahead. For the simple reason that they revel in each others' successes or failures. **A**



A hand-crafted miniature city



Filming the opening crawl for Star Wars